MORDOSSYR
THE GAMBLE

History

History does not start with a beginning. It starts with a wound. Everything before it is simply gone. And so begins the story of Scyndos, with not a clear memory of what the land held before it split.

I. The Sundering (0 SY)

On the longest day of the year, mid-harvest celebration, the sky split - not a storm, not an eclipse, but a fracture, as though the heavens were glass under pressure. Rain fell upward. Plague and rot swept the lowlands. Prayers to every god went unanswered. The earth itself tore open, and where it tore, the Wound (also called the Fracture) remains to this day, a permanent scar across the land that served as a reminder of the cataclysm.

Maybe it was the prayer of a hundred beating hearts or the last wishes of a thousand dying souls, but an answer arrived. As the Fracture threatened to swallow everything, the Bearer, a being of immense, uncertain nature, anchored the remaining land and held it together, staying still on all fours until time itself enveloped their being in dust and memories. This brought the survivors roughly a century.

But it seems the curse returned to the land as resources were scarce and greed once again played its hand.

II. Aeon of Strife (0-100 SY)

A century of survival on scraps, held together by the Bearer's sacrifice. Resources dwindled. Old patterns of greed reasserted themselves among the survivors almost immediately: humanity didn't learn anything from the first fall.

III. Age of Veil (101-113 SY) - The Order of the Balance

After 101 years, when hope had effectively run out, a stranger arrived. Garbed in clothes of mourning, it was perhaps empathy that drew her to the fracture. She was blessed with magic to establish order to the chaos that ravished every corner of

Scyndos. Lighting the Everburning Candle, a flame that sits in the First Light and has never gone out since, she spent 12 years building a new frame for this broken land. And thus, as the Four Pillars rose under her command, the Order of Balance lit the dawn of a new world.

The first pillar brought identity - a ledger to record all names so nobody is forgotten.

The second pillar brought reverence - a faith to remember the Bearer's unending resolve to hold the land from drifting apart.

The third pillar brought coin - a concord to build back trade for all those who toiled for resources.

The fourth pillar brought survival - a guild to retrieve those who had been separated across the lands.

And when the fourth pillar was raised, and the dawn she had promised finally held steady in the sky, she left Scyndos and its people, with nothing but her light to remember her by.

IV. Age of Descent (114-128 SY) - The Corruption of the Pillars

Peace has a way of feeling permanent right up until it isn't. For twelve years, no one noticed the weight settling in.

Granaries that had fed whole districts for a decade ran dry within a single season, and the Concord, which once promised trade for all who toiled, now traded only with those who'd already learned to hoard. Villages went hungry for days while the rich never missed a meal.

Sickness followed scarcity, the way it always does. The Ledger, which once recorded every name so that no one would be forgotten, now recorded silence where the poor used to be. A family that couldn't pay the registration fee simply stopped existing on paper, and a person who doesn't exist on paper cannot be helped by anyone who only ever looks at paper.

The Guild, meant to retrieve the separated and the lost, began charging for the search. The existence of those who were lost and their fate depended on the coin families had. While the nobles reunited with long lost cousins, the poor were forced into a fate of being the last of their family line.

And the Faith, which had once knelt beside her at the lighting of the Everburning Candle, now spoke her name so rarely that the youngest generation of Scyndos had begun to doubt she'd ever been more than a story told to frightened children. The Bearer's stillness was reverence enough, they were told. The woman who bled to build the pillars protecting them did not need to be remembered to have done it.

By the fourteenth winter, the graves outnumbered the granaries. People who had nothing left to lose, the ones without names, without registry, without protection stopped waiting for a miracle and chose to seek her out instead.

Grace conferred twice often reduces its value. She agreed to intercede, but not freely this time. She cautioned them that peace bought once and squandered would not be given a second time without a price they would never forget. And so she asked for a barter, a trade of fate itself, freely offered by those willing to give up their own future for Scyndos'. Seven came forward, names history has never fully agreed upon, and gave what was asked of them, and order was restored a second time.

What followed felt, for a while, like the world made whole again. The Ledger recorded every name without favor, the granaries filled and fed everyone across the land, the Guild and the Concord performed their duties as they were intended to, and an entire generation grew up believing peace was simply how the world worked.

Order was restored. Peace washed over the lands, until one day the illusion broke into a thousand shards. After 12 long years during the week of the Harvest, rumors started to surface. Seven people across Scyndos had vanished without a trace. No note, no goodbyes. And thus began a cycle marking the Age of Dusk.

V. Age of Dusk (128 SY-present, 236 SY) - The Cycle

And so, the twelfth Harvest brought with it not just yield but also the anticipation of loss. People who went missing bore the title of The Called.

First Light, a city that served as a beacon of hope now housed a graveyard of the Called adjacent to the Silent Vale. No bodies lie beneath any of the markers; there was nothing to bury. Families who lose someone to the Call are marked with the Sigil of Nyr (oblivion) and bound by an enforced vow of silence, presumably to "prevent panic," though cynics suspect it's to prevent the pattern from ever being publicly proven.

The descent had begun over again. Corruption had sown its roots into the pillars that once protected the society. What served as lessons and warnings had turned into habits, with no stranger this time around to protect those who suffered. The only being that kept the land from crumbling was the Bearer.

An endless cycle. A defined fate. As the twelfth Harvest returns, so does the reckoning. The name has been written, waiting for you to take notice. This is the Call.

Geography - Scyndos

Nobody knows how old the land is. All that is known is the oldest record of the Sundering, when The Bearer first stepped on Scyndos to hold the world from falling apart.

Since the Order of Balance collapsed, Scyndos has never again functioned as one unified realm. It survives now as a loose collection of city-states, each shaped by what its land could offer and who was strong enough to claim it.

Freshwater surrounds the southern and eastern coasts, feeding the farmland that keeps the whole continent fed. The Fracture itself remains dry at its center.

The Golden Sea

Farmland area (SW)
Inhabitants: Farmers, Shepherds, Guild of Carters
Run by: Smaller communal leaders, a lot of whom are in cahoots with the Merchant folk.

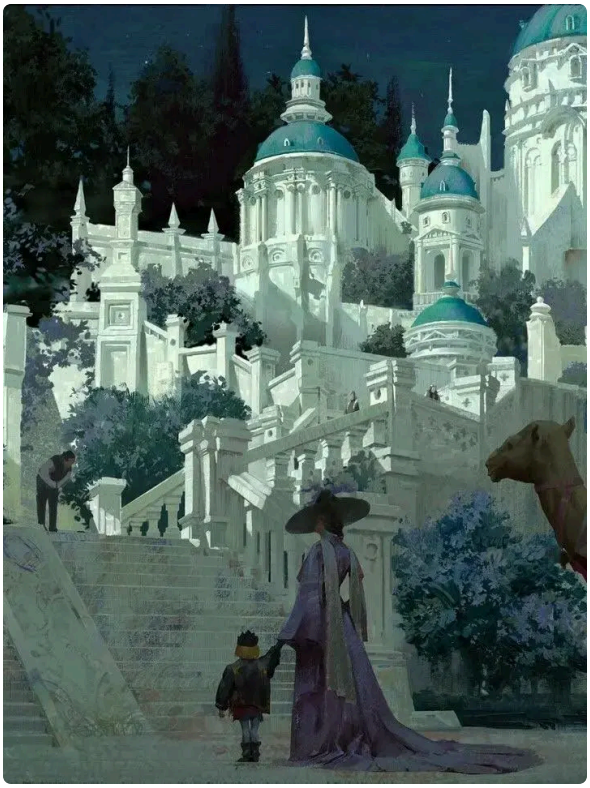
Shadowfenn

Forest land (SE)
Inhabitants: Woodworkers, Orchard owners, Rich land owners
Run by: No specific governing body as most plots are self owned and trades take place throughout Scyndos

High Crest

City state (W)
Inhabitants: Upper class merchants, nobility and their house servants
Run by: no one formally but the most influential person in high class society is Baron

Cassian Thorne.



The Warrens

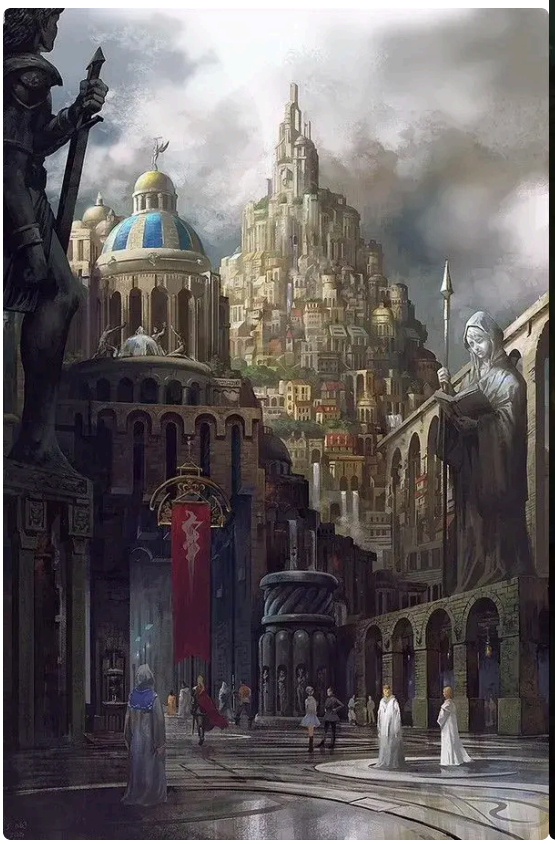
Located just outside High Crest inside the outer walls (at the edge), essentially slum-like conditions for lowly workers who engage in odd jobs like rat catching, construction, cleaning sewage, etc.
Run by: Two groups. The first is called *Crow's Nest* which is a faction that gathers intel on all inhabitants across Scyndos (Led by Madam Ophelia Gray). Second is *The Red Fist*, a youth gang secretly funded by the nobility to keep any riots from breaking out.

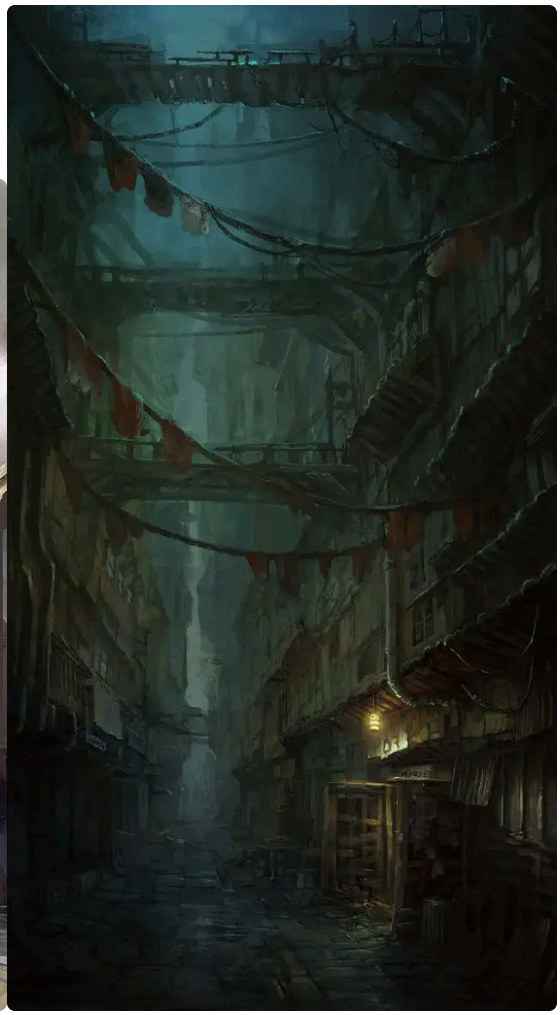
The Vigil Fort

Bastion (NW)
Inhabitants: The Vigilfolk, patrollers who try to investigate and archive any information about the Called, the Fracture and enforce curfew during the week of The Harvest.
Run by: Dallis the Dark Sister and Kniles the Whisperer

First Light

Previous Capital City (Central Region)
Location: Northern central region, largest city state of Scyndos. Has a citadel-esque structure in the centre called The Ledger. Apart from housing for locals and taverns, it also has the largest market and serves as the headquarters for the Concord to convene. The Guild also operates in the city as sellswords for anyone with coin. The main shrine of the Kneeling Faith for the Bearer is also located in First Light. There's also a slum area called *The Sink* where the Unmarked are forced to live.
Inhabitants: Commonfolk, Archivists and Custodians of the Ledger, Middle income merchants, the Guild, the people of the shrine, the Unmarked
Run by:
Scribe Merville Ordyn - The Head Custodian of the Ledger who has a say in any changes and retains absolute information pertaining to historical events.
Ferdinand Marlow - The Head of the Kneeling Faith
Captain Rosa Kael - Head of the Guild





Ironspyr

Location: A collection of underground cities that have been carved since the Fracture.
Inhabitants: Miners, Archaeologists, Smiths
Run by: No particular faction.

Other Features

Large stretches of Scyndos remain unmapped since the Sundering. Elders warn, consistently and seriously, that land isn't the only thing that changed that day.

The Teeth of Dawn: A jagged mountain range in the northeast born in the Sundering itself. It functions as a natural wall, shielding Scyndos' explored regions from whatever lies beyond.

The Silent Vale: Dense forest at the foot of the Teeth of Dawn, on Scyndos' side. Folklore holds that witches of considerable power live within, cursing any creature foolish enough to trespass. No confirmed sighting exists but the unknown holds a lot more than what meets the eye.

The Graveyard of the Called: Between First Light and the Silent Vale, row upon row of headstones stand close together, too close for coffins, because there were never any bodies to bury. Flowers, keepsakes, and small offerings from grieving families decorate the stones, refreshed every Harvest week whether or not anyone new has been added to the field that year.

The Six Factions of Scyndos

THE LEDGER

Geographical Presence: Headquartered in the citadel of the same name at the heart of First Light. Every city-state maintains a local registrar's office answering back to First Light, though enforcement thins considerably the further one travels.

Founded as: The first pillar of the Order of Balance, raised by the Unwed Widow to bring identity to a shattered land - a ledger to record every name, so that no one who survived the Sundering would ever again simply go unaccounted for.

Description of their work presently: Registration still happens, names are still recorded, debts are still tracked with precision but the impartiality that once defined the institution eroded over time and never fully recovered. Those who can pay the registration fee are recorded, protected, and accounted for. Those who cannot simply stop appearing in the books, and a person absent from the Ledger cannot be searched for, married, taxed, or mourned by any official process - they exist only to the people who still remember them personally, which the Ledger considers, quietly, someone else's problem.

Notable NPCs:

- **Scribe Merville Ordyn**: Head Custodian of the Ledger, the single living authority on what the citadel's archives actually contain. Precise, unreadable, and the only person in First Light who could confirm or deny the old rumors about the seven vanished, if he ever chose to.
- **Archivist Caleb Friar**: A junior archivist who is clumsy with his work and often known as the Eraser (since he messes up records). He hails from a family of scholars who served as archivists and scribes since the first order was established.

THE KNEELING FAITH

Geographical Presence: The primary shrine sits in First Light, built around the Everburning Candle itself. Smaller shrines and roadside chapels are scattered across

the continent. A grand chapel serves High Crest's nobility, humble waystone shrines dot the Golden Sea's farm roads, and a small monastic order maintaining a shrine deep within Ironspyr's cities mark their presence over Scyndos.

Founded as: The second pillar of the Order of Balance, raised to bring reverence - a faith built to honor the Bearer's unending, silent resolve to keep the land from drifting apart.

Description of their work presently: The Faith still tends its shrines, leads prayer services and funerary rites. The problem is what it has quietly stopped saying. Over the generations, sermons shifted their focus entirely to the Bearer, with no evidence left of any other entity that might have ever helped the people. The youngest generation of the devout believe the Everburning Candle to be the Bearer's beacon, a symbol of hope and resolve for their prayers.

Notable NPCs:

- **Ferdinand Marlow**: Head of the Kneeling Faith (*High Kneeler*), an unnervingly kind man who has spent his career believing the Widow's story was simplified for the faithful's own good, rather than erased for anyone else's convenience.
- **Penelope Cross**: One of the newly initiated *Obedient*, she's here to find more details about her guardian who was called twelve years ago. She has changed her name since to not bear the mark of Nyr.

THE CONCORD

Geographical Presence: Convenes formally in **First Light**, but its real strength runs through **High Crest**, where the wealthiest merchant houses set most of its actual policy, and the **Golden Sea**, whose farmland output it was originally built to fairly distribute. **Shadowfenn**'s self-owned orchards and timber plots trade with the Concord out of choice more than loyalty.

Founded as: The third pillar of the Order of Balance, raised to bring coin - a concord meant to rebuild trade for everyone who laboured to keep Scyndos fed and supplied after the Sundering.

Description of their work presently: Trade still moves through the Concord. It simply no longer moves evenly. Scarcity (real or manufactured), and increasingly

difficult for outsiders to tell apart, has become a tool rather than a hazard. Information about where goods are actually available is worth more, in practice, than the goods themselves. High Crest's old-money houses profit from every controlled shortage. The Golden Sea's farmers, who toil to feed the land, watch trade agreements get written further and further from their favour with every harvest.

Notable NPCs:

- **Baron Cassian Thorne**: High Crest's most influential noble, holding no official Concord title and needing none. Every major trade decision in Scyndos passes through his approval eventually, whether the Concord's charter admits it or not. Trades in Fracture-touched materials: minerals, relics, and curios pulled from the Wound's edge, most of unknown provenance and danger.
- **Felix Delacruz**: Controls the grain market - effectively sets harvest prices for three provinces and is widely (correctly) suspected of engineering shortages. He also claims to have ties to noble descendants and enjoys flaunting his wealth, hosting lavish banquets for other nobles during scarcity and drought.
- **Voice-Elect Arla Abbott**: The Concord's official spokesperson in First Light, incompetent but well-liked, and increasingly uneasy about how much of what she publicly announces she privately had no hand in deciding.
- **Madam Ophelia Gray**: Nominally a textiles magnate; actually runs the **Nameless Market**, an unofficial trade network that supplies goods to the Unmarked (see below) without requiring registry with the Ledger. Some suspect her benevolence comes with a cost, as no one questions the happenings of **the Sink** or the Unmarked.

THE GUILD

Geographical Presence: Jointly headquartered in First Light and High Crest, where its sellswords are available to anyone with coin, but its retrieval work (its original purpose) reaches everywhere Scyndos has people worth finding: from the depths of Ironspyr to the dense growth of Shadowfenn.

Founded as: The fourth pillar of the Order of Balance, raised to bring survival - a guild dedicated to retrieving those separated from their families and communities across the broken land.

Description of their work presently: The Guild still finds people. It has simply started charging for the finding, and the price climbs with the difficulty of the search, with often no results delivered once coin has been procured. Noble families in High Crest have been reunited with cousins lost for a generation within a matter of weeks. Poor families in the Sink file a request and are told that the search was never a concern of the guild to begin with. Savings of the poor often spent at local taverns on meat and ale, crushing any hope the downtrodden have of finding their families. What began as an act of mercy now runs, in all but name, as a mercenary company. A smaller sect of the Guild work with the Vigil to train for the Call, often collating any information or speculation about the event to prepare for the unknown.

Notable NPCs:

- **Captain Rosa Kael**: Head of the Guild, a hardened and fair-minded commander who inherited an institution already well down this path and has made only incremental progress pulling it back.
- **Keir Adel**: A scout who maps the edges of the Wound; one of very few people who is loyal to the Captain and trains for not just scouting but for finding out what happened to his village folk who were once called.
- **Ramsay Durn**: The "bully" archetype; a debt collector and enforcer who works Guild contracts nobles don't want their name attached to. He's always accompanied by his lackies and found drinking his pay away in taverns down the street marked with Nameless Market.

THE VIGIL

Geographical Presence: Based out of the Vigil Fort, a bastion in the northwest, with patrol routes running along Scyndos and concentrated attention on the Fracture itself.

Founded as: Not one of the original Four Pillars. The Vigil rose later, during the Age of Dusk, in direct response to the Cycle. It was never commissioned by the Order of Balance; it formed because someone had to investigate the Called, archive what little could be learned about the Fracture, and hold the line during the terror of Harvest week.

Description of their work presently: The Vigil enforces curfew during the week of the Harvest counting all heads in houses to record if anyone went missing, patrols the borders of the Silent Vale, and maintains the only serious archive of the called in Scyndos, although no patterns have been detected.

Notable NPCs:

- **Dallis the Dark Sister**: An old knight, scarred and eyepatched, who has led the Vigil's fieldwork for longer than most of her recruits have been alive, and trusts almost no one outside the Fort.
- **Kniles the Whisperer**: Raised in the Warrens, self-taught and self-made, now running the Vigil's intelligence network with a precision Dallis has learned to rely on.

THE UNMARKED

Geographical Presence: Concentrated most heavily in the Sink, First Light's slum for the unregistered. The Unmarked exist wherever the Ledger's reach has thinned: scattered camps at Shadowfenn's edges, informal settlements in the Golden Sea, and, increasingly, in Ironspyr's deepest, least-audited tunnels.

Founded as: Not founded at all, in any formal sense - the Unmarked are what's left when a family can no longer afford registration and simply stops existing on the Ledger's books. Over the cycles, the Unmarked suspected the involvement of the Ledger when it comes to the called and hence refused to register their names altogether believing this would prevent their name from being called. Two cycles ago, an unmarked did go missing as well, but somehow the inhabitants continue to live under these circumstances, as if it weren't by choice.

Description of their work presently: What was once simply a byproduct of institutional neglect has become something closer to a community, and in some quarters of the Sink, something closer to a resistance. Since their names aren't recorded, the Ledger and other pillars do not extend any assistance to this group. Instead, the Unmarked practice mutual aid, and live under constant, quiet pressure from factions like the Warrens' Red Fist, which exists largely to make sure their frustration never organizes into anything the nobility would have to actually answer for and any incidents are silenced immediately.

Faction Name	Presence	Professions	NPCs
The Ledger	Citadel in First Light (HQ); local registrar offices in every city-state, with enforcement thinning the farther from First Light	Custodians, archivists, scribes, clerks, registrars	Scribe Merville Ordyn (Head Custodian); Archivist Caleb Friar ("the Eraser")
The Kneeling Faith	Primary shrine in First Light (Everburning Candle); grand chapel in High Crest; waystone shrines across the Golden Sea; monastic order in Ironspyr	Priests/clergy ("Kneelers"), initiates ("the Obedient"), shrine-keepers	Ferdinand Marlow (High Kneeler); Penelope Cross (newly initiated Obedient)
The Concord	Convenes in First Light; real power in High Crest and the Golden Sea; trades with Shadowfenn by choice	Merchants, traders, grain/market controllers, spokespeople, landlords, wood workers, black-market brokers	Baron Cassian Thorne; Felix Delacruz; Voice-Elect Arla Abbott; Madam Ophelia Gray
The Guild	Jointly headquartered in First Light and High Crest; retrieval work reaches Ironspyr and Shadowfenn. Smaller group trains for the Call with the Vigil.	Sellswords, retrieval scouts, debt collectors/enforcers, Vigil-aligned Call researchers and warriors	Captain Rosa Kael; Keir Adel (scout); Ramsay Durn (enforcer)
The Vigil	Vigil Fort (northwest bastion); patrol routes across Scyndos, concentrated on the Fracture and Silent Vale	Knights, field patrollers, intelligence agents, archivists (of the Called)	Dallis the Dark Sister; Kniles the Whisperer

Faction Name	Presence	Professions	NPCs
The Unmarked	The Sink and The Warrens (First Light and High Crest slum, heaviest concentration); scattered camps in Shadowfenn, the Golden Sea, and deep Ironspyr	Unregistered laborers, mutual-aid organizers, black-market traders (via Nameless Market ties)	

Campaign Disclaimer

Welcome to Mordossyr - The Gamble. First and foremost, thank you for showing interest and willing to be yoinked to this world.

I plan on running this campaign from December (Week 1) on Saturday afternoons (IST) and for now it's definitely going to be 10+ sessions. Depending on life and holiday season, I know we shall face some scheduling issues. If that is the case, this will split into two arcs with temporary conclusion/cliffhanger for arc 1.

As for backstories, I shall post more about the world, common knowledge and history by this weekend/mid next week. This world will have communities you can choose to be a part of apart from the traditional 5e backgrounds. For any questions about the world that might help with character creation, you can always ping me and we can hop on a call when I'm not corpo-slaving.

Character creation and Backstory -

For now, we shall start at level 5 because that's the highest player level I have run a mini campaign for. Combat isn't my favourite part to run and I'm still learning so I'm trying to make this easier for all of us by keeping the table at level 5. If I feel more comfortable running combat for higher levels, I shall consider a level up (during the planning phase/between actual sessions after players hit a milestone).

As for your origins, backstories, etc. I will be conducting individual RP session zero apart from the group session zero before you begin character creation. If you choose to have backstories that are shared/where you are acquainted with another character, we can run a combined session zero instead for those pairs/groups. I would prefer everyone going through this cause 1. you wont spend half of first session figuring out how your character would behave 2. you find something from the past to connect to when the first session takes place

A common understanding would be that players are aware in character of the existence of backgrounds other characters come from. For example, if player A is from place X and player B is from place Y, it isn't mandatory for player A to know player B but both players would know about Place X and Place Y.

I would be posting some questions that would help me understand your character better and their place in this world, what inspired you as a player to create them,

basically details other than surface level stuff. I promise your answers won't be wasted.

Finally, the X-card system (I feel this is necessary to clarify early-on as the world is dark). While X-card works during sessions, I am still fleshing this world out. I will be sharing the Lines and Veils sheet (standard template) for all players to help me understand what the limit on things is. The last thing I need is for people to step away from my table because they were icked out or felt uncomfortable overall, I know the world is dark but I want the table to be a safe space for my players. If I text you to clarify any lines or veils, please don't brand me a tyrant - it is simply to understand what part of it affects you instead of something being straight up banned.

Finally, a note from a novice trauma provider - I'm still very new to GMing. I know I have run a mini campaign before but I still find myself second-guessing all my concepts, overthinking every tiny bit and I'm already feeling the pressure of GMing again for this table cause y'all are amazing players. I'll do my best to make this a smooth campaign, make sure this is worth the time, energy and effort you're spending at this table and overall ensure you have a fulfilling experience playing here. If I make mistakes, please bring it to my attention so I don't repeat them. I appreciate all honest feedback cause I'm always looking to improve.

On that note, your fate has been played. What lies ahead, we shall find out.

Consolidated Lines and Veils

Table Rules

Hi, I'm Smoo. I like D&D. I rarely run games. But I'm running one now so here's the DM profile:

Philosophy: The dragon is always optional, the consequences are not.

Table vibe: RP junkie, doing my best to build narratives that feel rewarding. Combat isn't my favourite part but I try to make it fun for every player at my table.

Banned Content:
Spells (for now): Interplanar spells, Silvery barbs, Conjure animals
Other content: Backgrounds which give feats
Don't try to play in bad faith and we'll be good.

Table Link: Always in VC chat during a game. Will be posted in handouts when we hold session 1.

TABLE RULES AND ETIQUETTE

Flanking
+2 if Large or smaller creature, and only effects creature who don't have Blindsight, Tremorsense etc. Rest have immunity to Flanking.

Healing potion
Action/out of combat: full heal, bonus action: roll to heal

Help action
Only if you're proficient and backing it up with a valid reason.

Dazed
A dazed creature can only do one of the following things on their turn: move, use an action, or use a bonus action. Reactions are unavailable to them. If a creature becomes dazed during their turn and they have already used an action, BA or movement, their turn ends. The cure ailment power, lesser restoration spell, and greater restoration spell remove the dazed condition. At the GM’s discretion, other powers, spells, or effects might also remove the dazed condition. When a dazed creature is affected by a spell or effect that gives them an extra action on their turn (like the haste spell or the fighter’s Action Surge feature), they can still take this extra

action, in addition to the movement, action, or bonus action allowed by the dazed condition.

Rule of cool
Idm cool shit, but nothing that is just a reason to break the game. If it's cool and we agree to it, go for it!

Checks
Not everything requires a roll if you describe it specifically. example: "I'd like to investigate" would be vague in a wizard's study compared to "I'd like to open the drawer and check what it holds."
Please try to avoid using phrases like "I'd like to roll insight/I'd like to roll a strength check for this." I know rolling the dice is fun but just stick to stating what you're trying to do, I'll clarify the attribute roll for it.

VC during combat
Please be mindful of what your mic picks up on while it isn't your turn. If you wish to suggest a strategy, use the VC chat. However, if it's something crucial like reminding them of an inspiration, bardic or bless (or similar buffs) in a tense situation, it's acceptable to speak out of turn for a moment.

Meta gaming
Try avoid acting on information that would be known to you as a player but not in character. Do not play jump rope with this etiquette, you're free to suggest why you might know something in character but final ruling cannot be contested post that. Also don't search up stat blocks mid combat, that's a big no-no.

Anything else?
Fairly new to DMing, so I do not have complete knowledge of all content out there. Any table rulings made shall be final for that session, we can always discuss it later post game and make changes as we go ahead. If I forget about something like an effect/roll incorrectly in case of disadvantage, please speak up even if it isn't your turn. If you're unsure of any information that was mentioned early on (could be due to ping issues on my end), idm repeating it later. But remember to have fun!